

POWER AND INFLUENCE OF THE HUMAN RESOURCES FUNCTION THROUGH BOUNDARY SPANNING AND INFORMATION MANAGEMENT

Gail S. Russ

Illinois State University

Maria Carmen Galang

University of Victoria

Gerald R. Ferris

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign

The human resource management (HRM) function has realized a considerable increase in power, influence, and reputation, but it has not been examined from the perspective of organizational boundary spanning. Because boundary spanning's function of information control provides a source of power, it is helpful in explaining HRM's growing influence in US organizations. However, our conceptualization of the boundary spanning role needs to be refined to incorporate developments after its initial creation. Hence, an evolutionary model is proposed that depicts two stages that the boundary spanning role subsequently undergoes when the conditions for its initial creation are no longer present to justify its existence. Despite what we have termed "phantom threats," boundary spanners are able to maintain their influence through astute management of information that portrays their continued usefulness. This phase however cannot last forever, and boundary spanners need to discover new threats. A review of the development and evolution of HRM in the U.S. supports the proposed model. Because each of the three stages are reflected in the communication patterns of the boundary spanner, several propositions based on the notion of information richness and the nature of the language used in communicating with three critical groups (i.e., external contacts, management, and subordinate staff) are generated to test the model. Finally, suggestions for research are made.

Direct all correspondence to: Gail S. Russ, Department of Management and Quantitative Methods, Campus Box 5580, College of Business, Illinois State University, Normal, IL 61790-5580.

Human Resource Management Review,
Volume 8, Number 2, 1998, pages 125-148
All rights of reproduction in any form reserved.

Copyright © 1998
by JAI Press Inc.
ISSN:1053-4822

The political perspective of human resource management (HRM) at the organizational level has been suggested (Ferris & Judge 1991), but while empirical studies have shown this political view of organizations to be a viable alternative (e.g., the influence of interest groups in HRM practices), there is still an inadequate understanding of how HRM departments are able to gain and maintain power and influence (for an exception to this, see Galang & Ferris 1997). Boundary spanning, with its function of information management, has been shown as a determinant of influence in organizations, and we suggest that this is a possible answer. While many specific boundary spanning roles have been examined, such as sales representatives (Wall 1972), purchasing agents (Strauss 1962), boards of directors (Maniha & Perrow 1965), and legal departments (Macauley 1963), the HRM function has not been systematically analyzed from this perspective. In addition, our current conceptualization is incomplete and must be supplemented by what happens after the creation of boundary spanning roles. We present a conceptual framework for the boundary spanning role that considers its evolution from the initial functional rationale for the creation of such roles, to the institutionalization of its function, to its renewed search for functional justification in order to protect and increase its power base.

We argue that an evolutionary model is an alternative interpretation that accounts for the actions that HRM departments have been observed to take or engage in. HRM departments took on a boundary spanning role because of pressures from the external environment (e.g., legislation, unionization). But at some point these pressures eased off. In many cases this was because they had been addressed effectively, and hence no longer presented a threat to the organization. In other cases, this was because the environment had indeed changed into a less threatening one. At that point HRM faced the same dilemma that other organizational subunits face: how then to maintain its importance in the organization. We argue that it is this very issue that explains the changing roles and, indeed, transformation of the HRM function we've witnessed in organizations in recent years.

So, first we examine the boundary spanning literature as springboard for developing the evolutionary model, and then we apply the model to the development of the HRM function in the U.S. Finally, suggestions are made for future research.

RESEARCH REVIEW

Boundary spanning has been extensively studied, specifically with respect to the boundary spanner's dual functions of processing environmental information for the organization and representing the firm to the external environment (Adams 1976, 1980; Aldrich 1979). The boundary spanner's role as information processor helps to protect the organization from information overload, as the boundary spanner filters, interprets, and channels relevant information to appropriate divisions of the firm. The boundary spanner's role as external

representative can involve establishing and maintaining the organization's social and political legitimacy, and its public image. Indeed, we argue later in this paper and elsewhere that the increased power, influence, and reputation of the HRM function are at least partially a function of legitimizing and image-enhancing activities (Galang, Elsik, & Russ in press).

Organizations create boundary spanning roles in response to environmental contingencies which are considered to be important for the firm's well-being. Aldrich (1979) noted that boundary spanning roles also are selected by the external environment for their contribution to the exchange of information across organizational boundaries. The important functions that the boundary spanner serves are seen as increasing the boundary spanner's power and credibility within the organization (Hambrick 1981; Jemison 1984; Spekman 1979; Thompson 1967).

Organizational Boundaries

Weber (1947) emphasized the importance of boundaries in defining organizations by noting that observers are able to distinguish between members and non-members as a result of rules, enforced by authorities within the organization, which close off or limit outsiders. Overall, organizations are believed to control their boundaries in order to maintain their autonomy and reduce uncertainty. This uncertainty reduction is important in that members' actions are considered more predictable than the actions of non-members (Aldrich 1979). Implicit in this notion is the idea that the uncertainty associated with outsiders, or the external environment, is seen as a potential threat to or source of conflict for the organization.

However, organizations are open-systems, unable to successfully close off their boundaries from influence from the outside world (Thompson 1967). Whereas the concept of organizational boundaries relies on the assumption that authorities within the firm seek to maintain those boundaries, the concept of open systems recognizes that some individuals from the organization will have to cross those boundaries in order to deal with the external influences. These individuals serve the role of boundary spanners.

While Starbuck (1976) argued that boundaries of an organization are malleable (i.e., that is, they change depending upon who is observing the boundaries and what part or aspect of the organization is being observed), for our purpose of addressing the HRM function, we consider the employees with the responsibility for the HRM function as organizational members, and hence within the boundaries of the organization.

The Function of Boundary Spanning Roles

Boundary spanning roles involve "activities of members or agents of an organization that serve to functionally relate the organization to its environment" (Adams 1980, p. 328). Adams (1980) identified five classes of boundary activities: (1) transacting input acquisition and output disposal; (2) filtering

inputs and outputs; (3) searching for and collecting information; (4) representing the organization; and (5) protecting and buffering the organization from external threats and pressures. Aldrich (1979; Aldrich & Herker 1977) presented a more parsimonious classification of the boundary spanner's role consisting of information processing and external representation. Here, we focus only on the information processing function of the boundary spanning role.

In Adams' (1980) framework, the search for and collection of information is characterized by the need for two kinds of information: (a) information needed for normal decision making and policy formulation, and (b) information of unpredictable events which might affect the organization if they were to occur. Similarly, Aldrich (1979) saw the boundary spanner as scanning the environment for information relevant to strategic (long-term) planning, managerial (short-term) decisions, and technical developments. The importance of the boundary spanner's information processing role lies in protecting the organization from information overload. In concrete terms, the boundary spanner acts on some information autonomously, delays other information, and consolidates and interprets information and passes it on to the appropriate part of the organization. The ability of the boundary spanner to filter out irrelevant information and summarize and appropriately direct useful information becomes increasingly important with environmental turbulence, when there is an increased need for external information.

Adams (1980) did not consider the interpretation of information to be a boundary activity, arguing instead that interpretation is a subsystem activity. This perspective of the limited role in information processing is in conflict with that held by other theorists and our position in this paper. Aldrich (1979) went beyond Adams' (1980) categorization of this activity to include interpretation of external information. Aldrich and Herker (1977) noted, "The expertise of boundary role occupants in summarizing and interpreting information may be as important to organizational success as expertise in determining who gets what information, depending upon the uncertainty in the information processed" (p. 219). March and Simon (1958) suggested that the boundary spanner absorbs uncertainty by inferring information from external data and only passing on the inferences. Thompson (1967) suggested that the boundary spanner's power within the organization is determined by the degree of success in exercising discretion and interpreting external events to organizational members.

Creation of Boundary Spanning Roles

Organizations differ internally on many dimensions and also exist in different types of environments. Not surprisingly, organizations also differ in the number and type of boundary spanning roles which exist, and the degree to which these roles are formalized and differentiated. Several factors have been associated with these differences.

An internal factor linked to the number and type of formally-specified boundary roles is organization size. Smaller organizations are usually less

differentiated (Blau 1970), and can rely on its members to bring in information from the outside. Since smaller, less complex organizations are more flexible in many ways, they can adapt more easily to environmental changes, reducing the need for specialized, formal boundary-spanning roles (Aldrich 1979). As organizations grow, however, their structure becomes more complex and tasks become more differentiated, and successful organizations respond by creating boundary-spanning roles that match their internal complexity.

The type of core technology can also affect boundary spanning activities (Aldrich & Herker 1977; Jemison 1984; Thompson 1967). In a long-linked technology (e.g., an assembly-line manufacturer), the firm's desire to seal off the core technology from environmental influence prompts the creation of staff roles to interact with those forces. In a mediating technology where line roles involve interacting with boundaries (e.g., advertising firms), both staff and line personnel serve as boundary spanners.

Environmental factors are even more important. Thompson (1967) argued that as environments are perceived to be more heterogeneous, organizations create special structural units to deal with separate homogeneous segments. This allows the firm to disaggregate its environment to some degree, in order to make interacting with any one domain less complex. As the environment is increasingly segmented, the organization's structure is increasingly differentiated in response. This isomorphic tendency applies to the boundary activities as well, in that boundary spanning roles become more differentiated as the organizational structure and the external environment become more complex and differentiated.

Instability in the environment increases the need for more boundary-spanning roles (Thompson 1967). Stable environments, on the other hand, require less monitoring and less information processing, which results in a reduced need for boundary activities. One aspect of a changing environment is that resources, or sources of external influence, that were once dispersed can become concentrated (Aldrich 1979). For instance, special interest groups can form to unite previously unallied individual factions. These concentrations are essentially concentrations of power, which can prompt the organization to create new boundary-spanning roles (or enhance existing ones) to cope with the perceived new threat.

Finally, environments are believed to be either rich or lean in terms of the amount of information that is readily available to the organization, and the necessity of boundary-spanning roles is considered to be reduced in rich environments with "high environmental capacity" (Aldrich 1979). In times of organizational conflict, for instance, the need for information is increased, but the amount of available information is reduced. While Aldrich did not explain exactly how environments have more or less information, it seems plausible from his use of conflict situations to illustrate the point that he may have meant that necessary accurate information might be more difficult to acquire due to secrecy, rumors, or deliberate distortion of information. Aldrich posited that an organization needs more people functioning as boundary spanners in order to maximize the firm's chances that all available information is obtained.

These factors relate to the number of boundary-spanning roles that are required by the firm. Formalization of these roles occurs to the degree that the organization's structure becomes more complex in response to specific external pressures, that the firm's authorities appreciate this effect on the structure, and that the importance of a particular external environmental force is recognized (Aldrich 1979).

Boundary Spanning as a Source of Power

The influence of the boundary spanner is believed to result from the ability to handle critical contingencies for the organization, and from the dependence that evolves upon the boundary spanner as an interpreter of the external environment. This notion is reflective of theories of power in organizations which focus on the control of strategic contingencies (Hickson, Hinings, Lee, Schneck, & Pennings 1971; Pfeffer & Salancik 1978). Furthermore, control over information is used by boundary spanners as a power mechanism to influence decisions within the organization (Pettigrew 1972). By selecting, filtering, and interpreting the information that flows between the organization and the external environment, the boundary spanner has the opportunity to manage information in such a way as to serve his/her own purposes; that is, influence the perception/understanding of the relevant segments of the external environment as a critical concern for the organization. In the same way, how that information is conveyed to organizational members is another means to influence that perception.

Empirical studies have found support for the influence of the boundary spanner in purchasing decisions (Spekman 1979) and strategic decision-making (Jemison 1984). Hambrick (1981) also found that members of the top management team, whose function does not deal with critical contingencies defined by the organization's strategic and environmental requirements, are still able to increase their power through environmental scanning behaviors.

On the other hand, the boundary spanner's loss of power is also a possibility. Tolbert's (1985) study of organizational differentiation in response to resource dependence is relevant, although not placed within a boundary-spanning framework per se. Tolbert found that although the dependence on *nontraditional* sources of funding was associated with departmental differentiation, dependence on traditional sources was not. She interpreted her findings as an integration of the resource dependence and institutionalization perspectives. The resource dependence view states that institutions create more positions to handle relationships with external organizations on whom the focal organization is dependent (Pfeffer & Salancik 1978; Thompson 1967). The institutional view, on the other hand, states that organizations (and society as a whole) have shared expectations and understandings about appropriate behavior and procedures (DiMaggio & Powell 1983; Zucker 1977, 1983). Organizations experience these shared beliefs as pressures to conform in structure and behavior in order to be considered legitimate and to survive.

Tolbert (1985) suggested that the resource dependence view would only hold

when commonly accepted procedures did not exist; in that case, organizations would create more positions to handle those environmental exchanges. When procedures have been institutionalized, however, increased differentiation is not necessary, because the exchanges can become routinized. In this sense, the institutionalization of the interaction allows it to become a simple, stable task, rather than remaining a complex, uncertain one. Routinization has the effect of reducing one's power by decreasing or removing uncertainties, or by allowing substitutability (Hickson et al. 1971).

In referring to the boundary spanning role as a discretionary job, Thompson (1967) recognized the effect of routinization on power. To the extent that the environment is homogeneous and stable, boundary-spanning roles can become standardized and routine, reducing the number of boundary spanners needed to handle the function, but when important segments of the environment are heterogeneous and changing, the boundary-spanning role requires more autonomy, and the exercise of discretion enables the boundary spanner to become more powerful.

Routinization may be a measure taken by the organizational hierarchy to serve a control function as well, and not just to ensure that the organization is responsive to the environment. Because the very nature of boundary spanning demands that individuals interact with others who have different information, attitudes, loyalties, and goals, the possibility exists that the boundary spanner may come to identify more with outsiders than with their own organization. Routinizing the boundary-spanning role reduces this possibility by limiting freedom on interaction with outsiders through proscribing certain behaviors and reducing the autonomy of the boundary spanner. However, where routinization is not possible, which includes most of the upper-level boundary spanning roles, other mechanisms must be relied upon. For instance, the organization can rotate individuals between boundary roles and core roles to ensure continued identification with the organization (Aldrich 1979).

MODELS OF BOUNDARY SPANNING ROLES

As seen, previous research has taken a rational approach to the creation of boundary-spanning roles. Organizations are viewed as responding to increased environmental complexity, and the resulting high levels of uncertainty, by creating boundary-spanning roles to process information from, and disseminate information to, the various external segments.

Tolbert's (1985) findings have several implications for the evolution of boundary spanning roles. First, she found that resource dependence predicted organizational differentiation only for nontraditional funding sources. Implicit in this view is that there were no established, shared norms for dealing with the nontraditional sources. With traditional sources, however, mutually understood procedures existed, and resource dependence did not predict differentiation. Is it to be inferred, then, that as procedures become understood and routine, the number of positions that exist to handle the interactions actually

decrease? Apparently not, since resource dependence on nontraditional sources showed *no* relationship to departmental differentiation—not even a negative one. Taking a rational perspective, wouldn't it be expected that as procedures become institutionalized (to use Tolbert's interpretation), or more simple and routine (to use the more common description), that the actual number of positions needed would decrease? One might expect that this would also hold true for boundary spanning roles that dealt with external contingencies in general that become more stable, more homogeneous, and/or less important to the organization. Figure 1, then, presents a rational model of the creation and subsequent dissolution of boundary spanning roles, in which the organization creates boundary spanning roles to deal with external threats, and then dissolves (or reduces the number of) these positions as the threat is reduced.

Tolbert's (1985) findings suggest that the rational model does not necessarily prevail. Since no relationship was found between resource dependence and differentiation for traditional funding sources, it must be assumed that not only did a number of universities have relatively few positions to handle what had become routinized procedure, but that a number of them had relatively *many* positions to handle these interactions. One explanation comes from the view that boundary spanners are active members of the organizations who are not merely subjected to events in the organization, but are able to influence and shape them as well. In short, boundary spanners in these positions draw on their sources of power by using their ability to control information to protect their roles and continue to indicate to their organizations that they still serve a useful function. This might be referred to as the "Phantom Threat" phase, in which the boundary spanner can manipulate environmental information to promote the view within the firm that the external threats (or complex, heterogeneous, unstable segments) still exist.

Although the "Phantom Threat" phase has some intuitive appeal, it seems difficult to believe that in most cases boundary spanners would be able (however willing one might assume them to be) to maintain the pretense that they still served a useful role to the organization. Although boundary spanners may be the primary source of information in many instances, they are rarely the only source. Thus, a "Discovered Threat" phase might emerge, which depicts the boundary spanner as proceeding through the Phantom Threat phase, actively seeking out and eventually discovering new external threats (or complex environmental contingencies), or previously uncovered ones, which justify his/her role. Boundary spanners who fail to do so are in a precarious position of losing power and influence.

A model integrating the various phases that the external environment and subsequent organizational responses go through is presented in Figure 2. This model attempts to illustrate what might occur when a boundary spanner's role becomes unnecessary, either by institutionalization or removal of the threat from the environment by any other means. This is a situation that can have important implications for an organization, but which, to date, has not been addressed by the boundary spanning literature. The present analysis and conceptualization is an extension of Tolbert's (1985) research in that she only

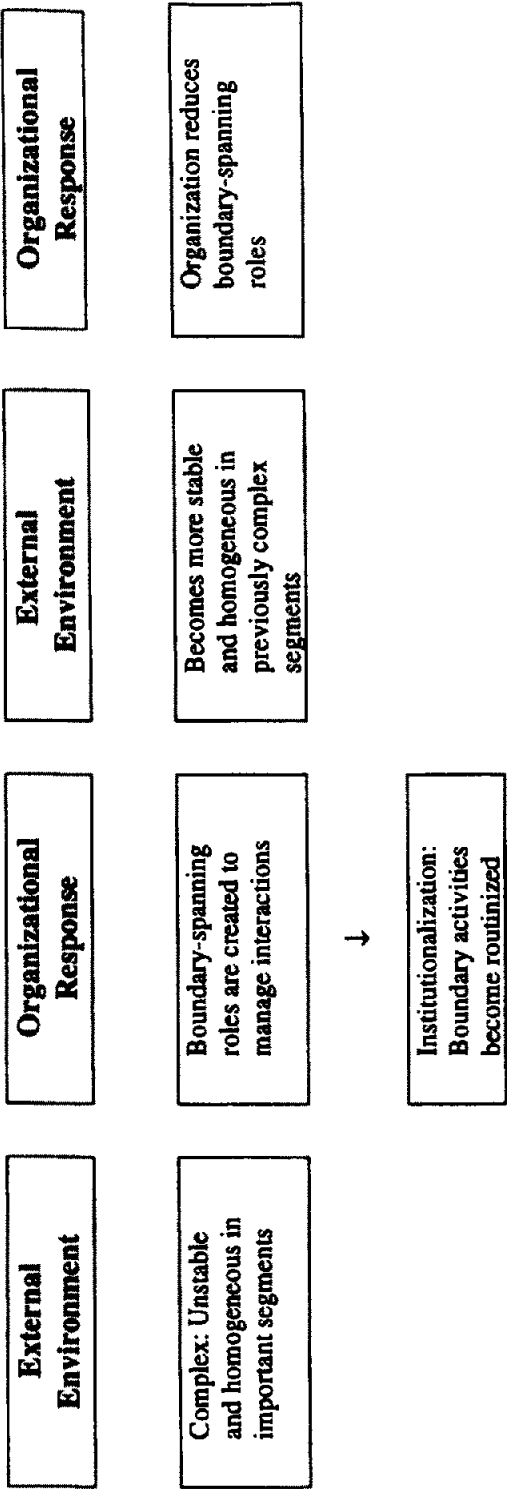


Figure 1. The Functionally Rational Model of Boundary Spanning Roles

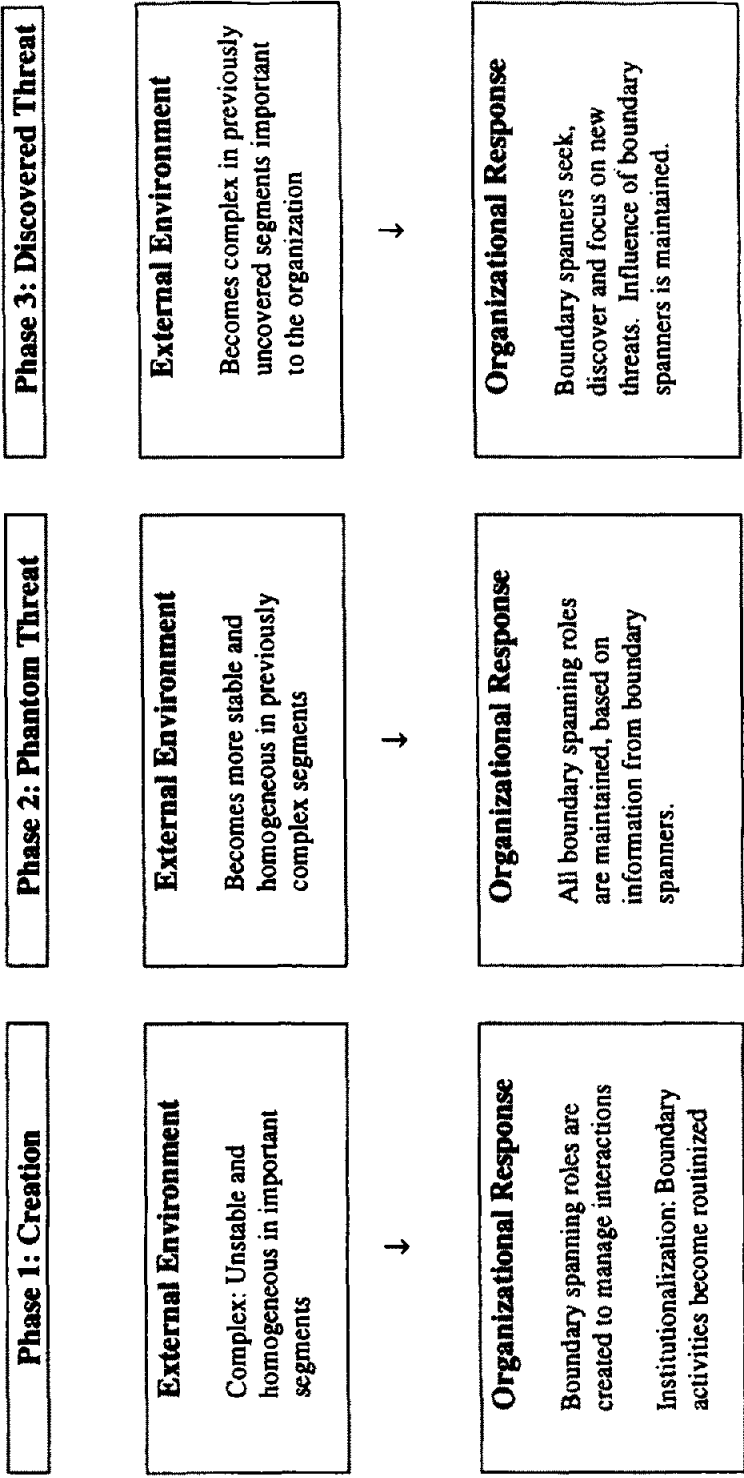


Figure 2. The Evolutionary Model of Boundary Spanning Roles

addressed the institutionalization of procedures, whereas this model discusses what might occur when a boundary spanner's *role*, or a major part of it, becomes institutionalized. In addition, Tolbert did not address the consequences to existing roles when procedures become institutionalized. The present model examines this process over time. Next, we examine the human resource management function in light of the various stages of this model.

THE HUMAN RESOURCES FUNCTION AND THE EVOLUTION OF BOUNDARY SPANNING ROLES

One organizational function that has been gaining prominence is human resource management (HRM) (Ferris, Rosen, & Barnum 1995; Foltz, Rosenberg, & Foehrenbach 1984). Despite its increased importance within the firm, HRM has not been examined in terms of boundary spanning, although it has been suggested (Martocchio & Ferris 1991). A boundary spanning perspective on HRM might help to explain its increased importance overall, and differences across organizations given similarly complex environments.

Phase 1: Creation of Boundary Spanning Roles

HRM in the United States has undergone a major change in its position within the firm since the mid-1960s, largely as a result of its increased importance in serving boundary spanning functions for the organization. Prior to the mid-1960s, the HRM department simply implemented corporate policy dictated by upper management (Mahoney & Deckop 1986). This was accomplished primarily by incorporating approved policy into standard personnel practices. HRM was not considered an influential or powerful department, but rather a maintenance function.

This situation changed dramatically, however, in subsequent years. Civil rights legislation and subsequent increased litigation during the 1960s and 1970s created a more turbulent and conflictual environment for organizations in terms of external monitoring of employer-employee relations. In response, organizations (particularly large ones) empowered the HRM department to increase its boundary-spanning role in terms of representing the firm to the external environment and interpreting external information for the organization (Edelman 1992). The heavy penalties for being found in violation of equal employment opportunity regulations had important implications for organizations, but the maze of government regulations and court decisions, often conflicting with each other, made it impossible for the firm to deal with the large amount of ambiguous information. The HRM function assumed this role for the organization. Since that time, the HRM function began to acquire increased stature and influence within the organization (the creation of new boundary spanning roles is represented in Phase 1 of Figure 2).

HRM scholars are not unaware of the contingent relationship between the HRM manager's new role and new power. As Werther and Davis (1985) stated,

"In the 1960s and 1970s, the central influence on personnel was again legislation. . . . These acts gave personnel departments a still larger voice—a voice that began to equal those of production, finance, and marketing executives in major corporations" (p. 36).

Phase 2: Phantom Threats

In the 1980s during the Reagan administration, however, considerably less emphasis was placed on compliance with discrimination and safety regulations. The rational model of boundary spanning roles, as discussed earlier (and depicted in Figure 1), would predict that a corresponding decrease would occur in the HRM's staff size and perceived importance within the firm. The evidence does not support this view. Instead, HRM continued to increase its importance.

To a limited extent there is evidence of "phantom threats" created by HRM (Phase 2 in Figure 2). The issue of employment-at-will is still of much concern to organizations (Youngblood & Bierman 1985, 1994). The employment-at-will issue revolves around a concept established in 1884 in *Payne vs. Western & A.P.R. Co.*, which essentially argued that an employer could fire an employee for a good reason, a bad reason, or no reason at all.

Since that time, the courts have allowed for five major exceptions to the employment-at-will doctrine: (1) statutory protection, such as that granted by Title VII of the Civil Rights Act and the Wagner Act of 1935; (2) due process protection, which applies to any employee whose employer is a government agent; (3) implied contract protection, where the employer has implicitly indicated that an employee will not be discharged without due process, as in an employee handbook, for instance; (4) implied consent of good faith and fair dealing, which prohibits an employer from discharging an employee in order to prevent the employee from reaping benefits of his/her labor; (5) public policy, where the courts have denied that employers have the right to terminate an employee who is fulfilling a public obligation (e.g., court duty), exercising a protected right (e.g., filing a workers' compensation claim), or refusing to commit an illegal act ordered by the employer.

Although the usual treatment of the employment-at-will issue focused on prohibitions for *unjust* discharge, and these exceptions have been very narrowly defined by the courts, little attention has been given to the prevalent belief among many managers that it is nearly impossible to terminate an employee for *any* reason. It is possible that information from the general news media has given this impression. It is also possible that HRM managers have fostered the view that only the employee has the "right" to terminate, and that legal recourse will be sought by and granted to any discharged employee.

Our suggestion gains credence from some of the HRM texts (e.g., French 1986) which recommend that the HRM department insist on lengthy procedures which the HRM department controls, to combat what we see as essentially a non-problem. The efforts of personnel specialists to professionalize (Baron, Dobbin, & Jennings 1986; Silberman 1983) can likewise be viewed as moving to take more control of the personnel function, maintaining influence

even when environmental contingencies decrease the importance of the function.

The Phantom Threat phase is consistent with the political perspective recently proposed as an alternative explanation of HRM in organizations (Ferris, Galang, Thornton, & Wayne 1995; Ferris & Judge 1991; Jennings 1994; Tsui & Milkovich 1987). For example, Gowler and Legge (1986) suggested that promoting a functionalist image of the personnel function (i.e., the personnel function as an adaptive response to contingencies faced by the organization) serves to justify its importance in the organization. Although not yet studied extensively for HRM, the use of language to gain influence and power in organizations is widely recognized (e.g., Pfeffer 1981), and the research by Kamoche (1995) indicates its potential for HRM. Similarly, the preoccupation by HRM practitioners with names and labels can be viewed as the gimmicks referred to by Drucker (1954) a long time ago: "The constant worry of all personnel administrators is their inability to prove that they are making a contribution to the enterprise. Their preoccupation is with the search for a 'gimmick' that will impress their management associates" (p. 275).

Phase 3: Discovered Threats

That the HRM function is now moving towards the Discovered Threat phase (Phase 3 in Figure 2) is suggested by the number of academic and practitioner articles which recommend that the HRM function should now be strategically-oriented and be included in corporate policy formulation (Butler, Ferris, & Napier 1991; Schuler 1992), rather than emphasizing HRM's contribution in protecting the organization from litigation associated with governmental regulation. HRM articles now discuss HRM's strategic role in increasing productivity and protecting the organization from foreign competition, as human resources are now regarded as contributing to an organization's competitive advantage (Huselid 1995; Pfeffer 1995; Wright, McMahan, & McWilliams 1994). As these concerns are considered by top executives to be the biggest threat facing American corporations today, the formulation of Strategic HRM places the HRM function in direct contact with the top ranks in the organization, ensuring that HRM issues are included in the main agenda (Dulebohn, Ferris, & Stodd 1995).

The shift in focus in HRM's role and targets occurring alongside organizational downsizing and restructuring, outsourcing of HRM functions, and decentralization or renewed interest by line managers in taking control of the function further strengthens our argument. One can easily see these events as forces serving to motivate the active search for new threats, and the theme of human resources as competitive advantage can only be advanced by those who can claim expertise in managing people within the exigencies of a changed environment. Thus, HRM is portrayed as being transformed, outsourced, reengineered, reinvented or rearchitected, and new roles for HRM are being carved out and offered to organizations to meet these new pressures: strategic business partner, internal consultant, change agent, or facilitator of organiza-

tional change interventions (e.g., Bender, Urban, Galang, Frink & Ferris 1996; Conner & Wirttemberg 1993; Kochanski & Randall 1994; Ulrich 1987). These roles, which require new competencies from HRM specialists, are argued to provide higher value at lower cost (Kochanski 1996; Yeung, Brockbank, & Ulrich 1994).

Of course, this is not to say that the new threats are not valid and real. As discussed in the proposed evolutionary model of the boundary spanning role, these represent Discovered Threats, either newly developed or previously uncovered segments in the environment. The point is that without recognizing these segments in the environment and positioning itself with its new role to claim jurisdiction, then the HRM department is in danger of losing its grip, and once again be relegated to a second-class status in the organization. The HRM department is in a unique situation in that its function can be performed by line management, thus it is necessary not only that these "new" threats are recognized and accepted as such by the organization but also that the HRM department is recognized as the appropriate party to effectively address these threats by either providing the needed expertise directly, or by performing an internal consulting role to equip line management with the skills to adequately address such key HR issues.

In summary, the HRM function over the last twenty years supplies some support for the proposed model. Obviously, more systematic testing of this model is needed, however. We next offer some suggestions for research based on several propositions that can be generated from our proposed model.

SUGGESTIONS FOR RESEARCH

Propositions

The rational approach to the need for boundary spanners is that such roles exist in order to communicate across organizational boundaries in the context of a complex, heterogeneous, and unstable environment. To the extent that the evolutionary model is accurate, boundary spanners can then be expected to interact differentially with critical others (e.g., their direct superiors and top management, their support staff, and contact persons of the focus external segments), depending on the existing environmental context.

To address this issue, an information concept developed by Daft and Lengel (1986) is used in characterizing the form of the boundary spanner's interactions with critical others. Daft and Lengel suggested that information richness, the potential information-carrying capacity of data, is needed more in equivocal situations in order to reduce that equivocality. They developed a hierarchy of media in terms of richness, with less rules and regulations typifying less rich, impersonal media, and face-to-face contact typifying rich, personal media. It should also be expected that a greater number of interactions would be needed to cope with unstable, complex situations. Thus, it would be expected to see boundary spanners having a greater number of interactions,

using richer media, for complex, ambiguous situations. Conversely, it would be expected to see fewer interactions and the use of less rich media to deal with routinized situations.

The content or substance of the interaction is likewise an important dimension of the boundary spanner's management of information to create shared meanings and construct realities. Interpretivist perspectives of organizational communication have suggested that the use of language and symbolic action is a means to gain power and influence (e.g., Conrad & Ryan 1985; Edelman 1985; Pondy 1977). Eisenberg (1984) argued that ambiguity in organizational communication enables the construction of meanings and can be used as a conscious strategy in a self-serving way to protect or enhance one's position. Indeed, some research has shown that powerful executives often attempt to protect their privileged positions through intentional vagueness and equivocation, thus using ambiguity strategically (Williams & Goss 1975). Galang and Ferris (1997) demonstrated that the HR department's symbolic actions was related to its power and influence in the organization.

A useful *a priori* categorization of language used in testing our conceptual model is the distinction between rhetoric and plain speaking (Kamoche 1995). Rhetorical language is effective in arousing emotions and conveying messages beyond the actual meaning of the words themselves. It can be expected that boundary spanners resort to rhetoric more when the external environment does not pose real threats to the organization.

Boundary spanners interact with three main groups: the various contact persons in the external environment, their own supervisors and other upper management individuals, and their own subordinates (in cases where the boundary spanner is the head of a department). When the boundary-spanning activity is in response to a complex and ambiguous environment, it seems plausible that communications with all three segments would necessitate the use of rich media (e.g., face-to-face meetings) in order to reduce the equivocality of received information, as well as to reduce the ambiguity of any information that they themselves might be giving to the contact individuals. Subtle nuances that might be lost in less rich media could have important implications for the boundary spanner's ability to correctly interpret the information for the organization, thus, rich media should be preferred. Likewise, there is also less of a need for rhetoric at this point, and it may even interfere; plain speaking would be all that is necessary. This leads to the first three propositions:

Proposition 1. Interactions with contact persons of external segments will be characterized by the frequent use of rich media and less rhetorical language when the boundary spanning activity is perceived to be in response to a real threat to the organization.

Proposition 2. Interactions with upper management will be characterized by the frequent use of rich media and less rhetorical language when the boundary-spanning activity is perceived to be in response to a real threat to the organization.

Proposition 3. Interactions with subordinates will be characterized by the frequent use of rich media and less rhetorical language when the boundary-spanning activity is perceived to be in response to a real threat to the organization.

The above propositions reflect a rational approach to the creation of the boundary spanning role. The Phantom Threat stage of the proposed model suggests, however, that external situations which cease to be a threat to the organization may not lead to fewer boundary-spanning roles, as the rational approach would imply. Instead, it is hypothesized that the boundary spanner is motivated to maintain the position of power and influence which s/he has attained by serving in that role, and is in a position to create the impression that the threat still exists. Testing this part of the model has obvious difficulties, since boundary spanners are not likely to admit that they engage in such activities. (Indeed, it is not necessary to this model to posit that deception occurs at a conscious level, since it is entirely possible that the boundary spanner may believe in the importance of certain activities in their own right, as in the case of supporting affirmative action programs even without government regulations requiring them.)

The characteristics of the boundary spanner's interactions, however, would differ across the three critical segments, as well as with the nature of the interactions prior to the shift or change in the environmental conditions. Highly complex situations, as had been noted, should require the use of richer media in information exchanges with external contacts in order to reduce the equivocality. It can be inferred, then, that more stable situations, as would be the case where external threats no longer exist or where the organization has devised adequate procedures to deal with the threat, should require the use of less rich media. Likewise, the use of rhetorical language remains unnecessary. The following proposition is suggested:

Proposition 4. Interactions with contact persons of external segments will be characterized by the use of less rich media (or, decreased use of rich media) when the boundary-spanning activity is perceived to be in response to a situation that is no longer a real threat to the organization, or where the external contingencies surrounding the threat have stabilized and the organization has developed adequate procedures to handle the situation; plain speaking will continue to be used.

The Phantom Threat stage of the proposed model suggests that boundary spanners will use their role as gatekeepers to maintain the impression that the external threat still exists. The media richness theory developed by Daft and Lengel (1986) does not address the issue of the validity of the information that is being conveyed, but it does imply that richer media may be used to symbolically indicate the importance or urgency of the subject matter. Boundary spanners in the Phantom Threat phase are hypothesized to represent to upper management that the external threat still exists. In this situation, rhetorics serve the purpose better than plain speaking. Therefore, the following proposition is suggested:

Proposition 5. Interactions with upper management will be characterized by the frequent use of rich media and rhetorical language even when the boundary-spanning activity is perceived by the boundary spanner to be in response to a situation that is no longer a real threat to the organization, or where the external contingencies surrounding the threat have stabilized and the organization has developed adequate procedures to handle the situation.

The Phantom Threat phase of the model also suggests that, just as with external contacts, interactions with subordinates, or units of the organization whose activities are in response to the external threat, should become more routine when the external situation is no longer a real threat to the organization. Therefore, the following is suggested:

Proposition 6. Interactions with subordinates, or units of the organization whose activities are in response to the external threat, will be characterized by the use of less rich media when the boundary spanning activity is perceived to be in response to a situation that is no longer a real threat to the organization, or where the external contingencies surrounding the threat have stabilized and the organization has developed adequate procedures to handle the situation; plain speaking is expected to be continued as well.

In short, the Phantom Threat phase depicts the boundary spanner as shifting to using less rich media and communicating less often with both external contacts and subordinate staff, while maintaining the use of rich media and frequent communications with upper management, but shifting to the use of rhetorical language in order to maintain its power and influence in the organization.

Finally, the Discovered Threat phase of the model suggests that the boundary spanner will search for new threats in the environment. However, the discovery of a new threat by the boundary spanner does not automatically mean recognition of the threat by critical others in the organization (especially top management), nor of his/her role in dealing with the threat. The situation is somewhat similar to the Creation phase, except that there are already boundary spanners who are motivated to maintain their influence within the organization. Rather than creating new boundary spanning roles to deal with the newly-discovered threats, therefore, it is reasonable to find the existing boundary spanner asserting his/her capabilities. Only when these new threats are recognized, and the existing boundary spanner's new role acknowledged will the communication patterns with external contacts and upper management be similar to those suggested in Propositions 1 and 2, where the boundary-spanning role is created in response to external segments that are perceived to be real threats to the organization. Therefore, the following is suggested:

Proposition 7. Boundary-spanning activities that are perceived to be in response to new, real threats to the organization will be characterized by a greater number of interactions with contact persons in the external segment

and with upper management, using rich media, particularly face-to-face interactions.

It was suggested in Proposition 3 that interactions with the support staff would require richer media. When new threats are first being recognized and assessed, however, it is possible that the situation will be so complex and unknown that no action can be taken. Boundary spanners may interact with external contact persons and upper management in order to understand the situation, and to develop appropriate responses. So, it is suggested that support staff will be minimally involved in the early stages of searching and recognizing an external threat. Their involvement should increase, however, as the external situation is defined by the boundary spanner.

Proposition 8. Boundary spanners should have few interactions with support staff about newly perceived threats to the organization.

Figure 3 summarizes the propositions discussed above for each of the phases/stages in our evolutionary model.

Directions for Model Testing and Future Research

It is suggested that a given department can exist at any number of the stages identified in the proposed model at any point in time. That is, the department can be engaged in boundary-spanning activities in response to real threats (the first stage of the model), activities that are designed to create the false impressions that the external threat still exists (the Phantom Threat phase), and activities that are searching or assessing potential threats (the Discovered Threat phase). Therefore, a cross-sectional study of a single department is proposed as a first step in testing the model, where boundary-spanning activities related to various external issues that differ in whether or not they pose as threats to the organization are examined. In addition, by staying within the same department, between-operational departments variation will be controlled for, and the design should be more sensitive to differences in type of communication media used by boundary spanners. The validity of the model will however be ultimately confirmed with a longitudinal study where changes in environmental conditions and the corresponding responses, as laid out in our propositions, can be tracked according to the evolutionary phases in the proposed model.

In a cross-sectional study, department heads and top management would be asked to rate several current environmental factors for their importance to the organization. For the particular case of the HRM function, these issues would include government regulations for civil rights issues and occupational safety, employment-at-will, productivity and foreign competition. These measures will indicate the perceived relative importance of these issues to the organization as a whole. Non-perceptual measures also can be obtained for some of these issues. In addition, respondents will be asked to indicate, for each issue, whether they see these factors increasing or decreasing in importance to the

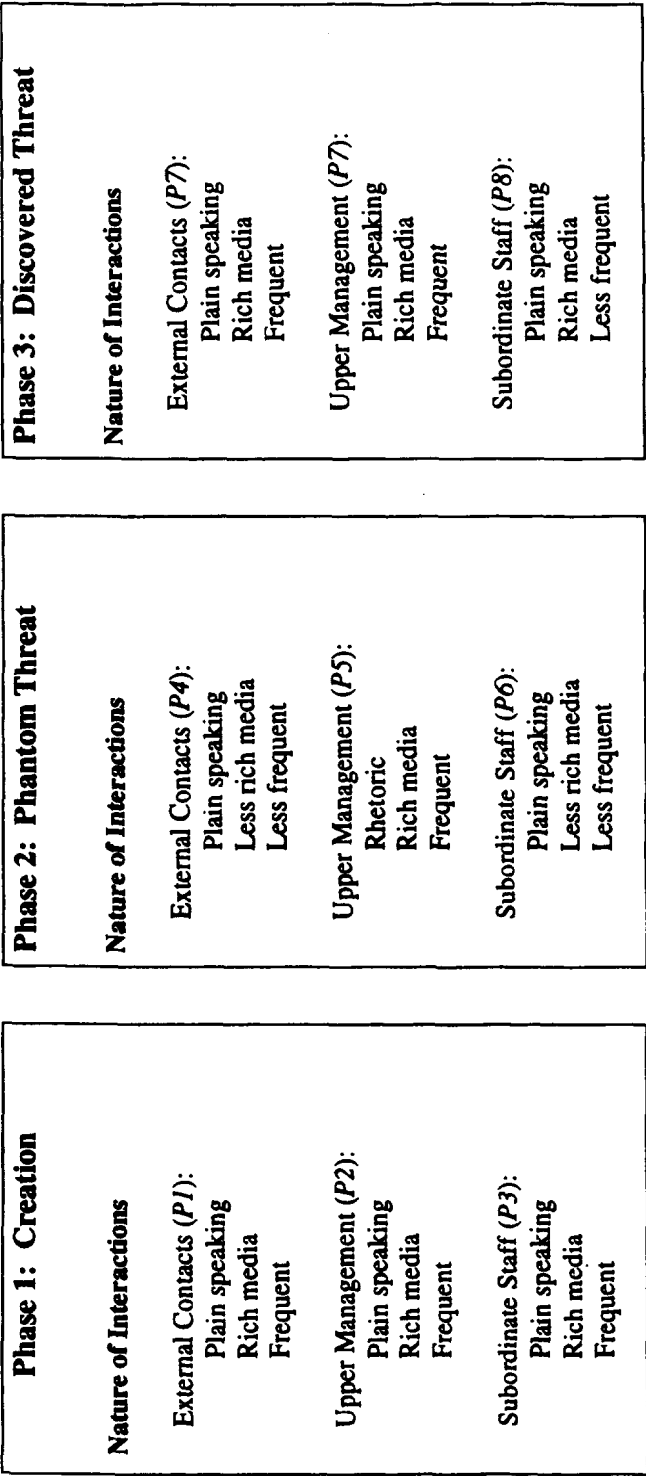


Figure 3. Propositions for the Evolutionary Model of Boundary Spanning Roles

firm over the next three years. (At this stage of the development of the HRM function, it is expected that analysis of the communication pattern data will reveal that issues such as complying with government regulations will be more routinized whereas productivity and foreign competition will require more time and richer media.)

To test the various hypotheses relating to differential communication patterns with subordinates, upper management, and external contact persons, the HRM managers will be asked the extent to which they deal with these groups on these issues. HRM managers will also be asked, for each issue, how much of the time spent occurs in face-to-face meetings, telephone conversations, writing memos or letters, or simply following rules and regulations. Likewise, communications from the HRM managers can be content-analyzed for the language used.

When analyzed for each separate HRM issue, this information on the percentage of time devoted to each issue, the media used, and the language used should correspond to which of the specific issues are perceived as complex (thus requiring face-to-face interaction to reduce equivocality) or simple and straightforward (allowing the use of less rich media). For instance, recall that it was hypothesized that "phantom threats" will be typified by a low level of interaction with external contact persons and staff members, using less rich media, but a relatively higher proportion of time communicating with upper management using richer media. Maintaining top management's perceived importance of these issues, however, would require richer media and more information exchange to ensure that the external threat was still believed to be an important threat.

Finally, further research should investigate the implications of communication patterns for power and influence. Boundary spanners who do not engage in the communication behaviors explicated in the propositions should be found to have less power and influence than those who do.

CONCLUSION

A model that conceptualizes the evolution of boundary-spanning roles has been presented. This model questions the rational approach that has been taken in the past, and addresses the situation where the threat which initiated a boundary-spanning role either no longer exists in the external environment or has been neutralized by routinized procedures. It was suggested that the boundary spanner will go through a period of maintaining that the threat still exists, but will then proceed to find new external threats to deal with, in order to maintain the power and influence which accrued to that position as a result of coping with critical linkages.

An examination of the growth of the HRM function to its present significance in organizations showed support for the proposed evolutionary model of boundary spanning roles. However, systematic testing still needs to be done to validate the model, and to confirm our interpretation of the developments

observed with respect to the HRM function. Suggestions for research were therefore also provided.

REFERENCES

- Adams, J. S. 1976. "The Structure and Dynamics of Behavior in Organizational Boundary Roles." Pp. 1175-1199 in *Handbook of Industrial and Organizational Psychology*, edited by M. D. Dunnette. Chicago: Rand McNally.
- . 1980. "Interorganizational Processes and Organization Boundary Activities." Pp. 321-355 in *Research in Organizational Behavior* (Vol. 2), edited by B. W. Staw and L. L. Cummings. Greenwich, CT: JAI Press.
- Aldrich, H. E. 1979. *Organizations and Environments*. Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall.
- Aldrich, H. E. and D. Herker. 1977. "Boundary Spanning Roles and Organization Structure." *Academy of Management Review* 2(2): 217-230.
- Baron, J., F. Dobbin, and P. D. Jennings. 1986. "War and Peace: The Evolution of Modern Personnel Administration in U.S. Industry." *American Journal of Sociology* 92(2): 350-383.
- Bender, J. M., T. F. Urban, M. C. Galang, D. D., Frink, and G. R. Ferris. 1996. "Developing Human Resources Professionals at ARCO Oil and Gas Company." Pp. 19-32 in *Human Resources Management: Perspectives, Context, Functions and Outcomes*, edited by G. R. Ferris & M. R. Buckley. Englewood Cliffs, Prentice Hall.
- Blau, P. 1970. "A Formal Theory of Differentiation in Organizations." *American Sociological Review* 35(2): 201-218.
- Butler, J. E., G. R. Ferris, and N. K. Napier. 1991. *Strategy and Human Resources Management*. Cincinnati: South-Western.
- Conner, J. and J. Wirtenberg. 1993. "Managing the Transformation of Human Resources Work." *Human Resource Planning* 16(2): 17-34.
- Conrad, C. and M. Ryan. 1985. "Power, Praxis, and Self in Organizational Communication Theory." Pp. 235-257 in *Organizational Communication: Traditional Themes and New Directions*, edited by R. D. McPhee and P. K. Tompkins. Beverly Hills: Sage.
- Daft, R. L. and R. H. Lengel. 1986. "Organizational Information Requirements: Media Richness and Structural Design: An Integrating Framework." *Management Science* 32(5): 554-571.
- DiMaggio, P. and W. Powell. 1983. "The Iron Cage Revisited: Institutional Isomorphism and Collective Rationality in Organizational Fields." *American Sociological Review* 48(2): 147-160.
- Drucker, P. 1954. *The Practice of Management*. New York: Harper.
- Dulebohn, J. H., G. R. Ferris, and J. T. Stodd. 1995. "The History and Evolution of Human Resource Management." Pp. 18-41 in *Handbook of Human Resources Management*, edited by G. R. Ferris, S. D. Rosen, and D. T. Barnum. Oxford, UK: Blackwell Publishers.
- Edelman, L. B. 1992. "Legal Ambiguity and Symbolic Structures: Organizational Mediation of Civil Rights Law." *American Journal of Sociology* 97(6): 1531-1576.
- Edelman, M. 1985. *The Symbolic Uses of Politics*. Urbana: University of Illinois Press.
- Eisenberg, E. M. 1984. "Ambiguity as Strategy in Organizational Communication." *Communication Monographs*, 51(3): 227-242.
- Ferris, G. R., M. C. Galang, M. L. Thornton, and S. J. Wayne. 1995. "A Power and

- Politics Perspective on Human Resource Management." Pp. 100–114 in *Handbook of Human Resources Management*, edited by G. R. Ferris, S. D. Rosen, and D. T. Barnum. Oxford, UK: Blackwell Publishers.
- Ferris, G. R. and T. A. Judge. 1991. "Personnel/Human Resources Management: A Political Influence Perspective." *Journal of Management* 17(2): 447–488.
- Ferris, G. R., S. D. Rosen, and D. T. Barnum. (Eds.) 1995. *Handbook of Human Resource Management*. Oxford, U.K.: Blackwell Publishers.
- Foltz, R., R. Rosenberg, and J. Foehrenbach. 1984. "Senior Management Views the Human Resource Function." In *Readings in Personnel and Human Resource Management*, edited by R. S. Schuler and S. A. Youngblood. St. Paul, MN: West Publishing.
- French, W. L. 1986. *Human Resources Management*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin.
- Galang, M. C. and G. R. Ferris. 1997. Human Resource Department Power and Influence Through Symbolic Action." *Human Relations* 50(11): 1403–1426.
- Gowler, D. and K. Legge. 1986. "Personnel and Paradigms: Four Perspectives on the Future." *Industrial Relations Journal* 17(3): 225–235.
- Hambrick, D. C. 1981. "Environment, Strategy, and Power Within Top Management Teams." *Administrative Science Quarterly* 26(2): 253–273.
- Hickson, D. J., C. R. Hinings, C. A. Lee, R. E. Schneck, and J. M. Pennings. 1971. "A Strategic Contingencies Theory of Intraorganizational Power." *Administrative Science Quarterly* 16(2): 216–229.
- Huselid, M. A. 1995. "The Impact of Human Resource Management Practices on Turnover, Productivity, and Corporate Financial Performance." *Academy of Management Journal* 38(3): 635–672.
- Jemison, D. B. 1984. "The Importance of Boundary Spanning Roles in Strategic Decision-Making." *Journal of Management Studies* 21(2): 131–152.
- Jennings, P. D. 1994. "Viewing Macro HRM from Without: Political and Institutional Perspectives." Pp. 1–40 in *Research in Personnel and Human Resources Management* (Vol. 12), edited by G. R. Ferris. Greenwich, CT: JAI Press.
- Kamoche, K. 1995. "Rhetoric, Ritualism, and Totemism in Human Resource Management." *Human Relations* 48(4): 367–385.
- Kochanski, J. T. (ed) 1996. "Special Issue on Human Resource Competencies." *Human Resource Management* 35.
- Kochanski, J. T. and P. Randall. 1994. "Rearchitecting the Human Resources Function at Northern Telecom." *Human Resource Management* 33(2): 299–315.
- Macauley, S. 1963. "Non-Contractual Relations in Business: A Preliminary Study." *American Sociological Review* 28(1): 55–67.
- Maniha, J. K. and C. Perrow. 1965. "The Reluctant Organization and the Aggressive Environment." *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 10(2): 238–257.
- March, J. G. and H. A. Simon. 1958. *Organizations*. New York: Wiley.
- Martocchio, J. J. and G. R. Ferris. 1991. "Performance Evaluation in High Technology Firms: A Political Perspective." *The Journal of High Technology Management Research* 2(1): 83–97.
- Mahoney, T. A. and J. R. Deckop. 1986. "Evolution of Concept and Practice in Personnel Administration/Human Resource Management (PA/HRM)." *Journal of Management* 12(2): 223–241.
- Pettigrew, A. 1972. "Information Control as a Power Resource." *Sociology* 6(2): 187–204.
- Pfeffer, J. 1981. *Power in Organizations*. Marshfield, MA: Pitman.
- . 1995. "Managing Human Resources for Competitive Advantage: Barriers to Change." Pp. 13–45 in *Managing Human Resources in the 1990s and Beyond*,

- edited by B. Downie and M. L. Coates. Kingston, ON: Industrial Relations Centre.
- Pfeffer, J. and G. R. Salancik. 1978. *The External Control of Organizations*. New York: Harper & Row.
- Pondy, L. R. 1977. "The Other Hand Clapping: An Information-Processing Approach to Organizational Power." Pp. 56-91 in *Reward Systems and Power Distribution in Organizations: Searching for Solutions*, edited by T. H. Hammer and S. B. Bacharach. Cornell: New York State School of Industrial and Labor Relations.
- Schuler, R. S. 1992. "Strategic Human Resource Management: Linking the People With the Strategic Needs of the Business." *Organizational Dynamics* 21(1): 18-31.
- Silberman, A. 1983. *Political Behavior in Organizations: The Case of the Personnel Managers*. Unpublished master's thesis, University of Wisconsin-Madison.
- Spekman, R. E. 1979. "Influence and Information: An Exploratory Investigation of the Boundary Role Person's Basis of Power." *Academy of Management Journal* 22(1): 104-117.
- Starbuck, W. H. 1976. "Organizations and Their Environments." Pp. 1069-1123 in *Handbook of Industrial and Organizational Psychology*, edited by M. D. Dunnette. Chicago: Rand McNally.
- Strauss, G. 1962. "Tactics of Lateral Relationships: The Purchasing Agent." *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 7(1) 160-186.
- Thompson, J. D. 1967. *Organizations in Action*. New York: McGraw Hill.
- Tolbert, P. S. 1985. "Institutional Environments and Resource Dependence: Sources of Administrative Structure in Institutions of Higher Education." *Administrative Science Quarterly* 30(1): 1-13.
- Tsui, A. S. and G. T. Milkovich. 1987. "Personnel Department Activities: Constituency Perspectives and Preferences." *Personnel Psychology*, 40(3): 519-537.
- Ulrich, D. 1987. "Organizational Capability as a Competitive Advantage: Human Resource Professionals as Strategic Partners." *Human Resource Planning* 10(4): 169-184.
- Wall, J. A. 1972. *The Effects of the Constituent's Informational Environment upon the Constituent-Boundary Role Person Relationship*. Unpublished doctoral dissertation, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill.
- Weber, M. 1947. *The Theory of Social and Economic Organization*. Translated and edited by A. M. Henderson & Talcott Parsons. New York: Oxford University Press.
- Werther, W. B. and K. Davis. 1985. *Canadian Personnel Management and Human Resources Management*. Toronto: McGraw-Hill Ryerson.
- Williams, M. L. and B. Goss. 1975. "Equivocation: Character insurance." *Human Communication Research*, 1(3): 265-270.
- Wright, P. M., G. C. McMahan, and A. McWilliams. 1994. "Human Resources and Sustained Competitive Advantage: A Resource-Based Perspective." *International Journal of Human Resource Management*, 5(2): 301-326.
- Yeung, A., W. Brockbank, and D. Ulrich. 1994. "Lower Cost, Higher Value: Human Resource Function in Transformation." *Human Resource Management* 17(3): 1-16.
- Youngblood, S. A. and L. Bierman. 1985. "Due Process and Employment-at-will: A Legal and Behavioral Analysis." Pp. 185-230 in *Research in Personnel and Human Resources Management* (Vol. 3), edited by K. M. Rowland & G. R. Ferris. Greenwich, CT: JAI Press.
- _____. 1994. "Employment-at-will: New Developments and Research Implications." Pp.

303–324 in, *Research in Personnel and Human Resources Management* (Vol. 12), edited by G. R. Ferris. Greenwich, CT: JAI Press.

Zucker, L. 1977. "The Role of Institutionalization in Cultural Persistence." *American Sociological Review*, 42(5): 726–743.

———. 1983. "Organizations as Institutions." Pp. 1–47 in *Research in the Sociology of Organizations* (Vol. 2), edited by S. Bacharach. Greenwich, CT: JAI Press.